# 10 The Railway Children

## Warm up

**List five things that you love most about your home. If you had to move houses and were allowed to take just one carton of things, which five things would you definitely take with you?**

**Let's read a story about three children who had to leave their home and move to a new one.**

There were three of them. Roberta was the eldest. Next came Peter and the youngest was Phyllis. They lived with their parents in a red-brick-fronted villa.

Father and Mother were always ready to play with the children and read to them. They were very happy but they did not know how happy till the pretty life in the Red Villa was over and done with, and they had to live a very different life indeed.

The change came quite suddenly on Peter's tenth birthday.

Two stern-looking gentlemen came to see Father that day. Father and Mother took them to the library. There was a lot of talking. The children heard boots go out and the front door shut.

Then Mother came in.

"Father's been called away," she said. "There's been some trouble but I want you not to ask me any questions about it. Be good and go to bed." They kissed her and went.

A few days later Mother came down to breakfast. She looked pale but she smiled and said, "Now, my pets, we're going to leave this house, and go and live in the country. I know you'll love it."

stern-looking: unfriendly-looking  called away: asked to stop what they were doing and to go somewhere else

A whirling week of packing followed – not just packing clothes, like when you go on a holiday, but packing chairs, tables, crockery, blankets, candlesticks and carpets! Then boxes were filled and the next afternoon, a cab came to take them to the station.

How was this packing different from the other packing that the children had done?

On the train the children enjoyed looking out of the window, but when it grew dusk and they were sleepy, they were roused by Mother saying, "Wake up, dears. We're there."

They woke up and stood shivering on the cold platform. The baggage was loaded onto a cart.

"Come," said Mother, "we've got to walk."

What made the children stumble?

The walk was dark and muddy. The children stumbled a little on the rough road.

Presently a great, dark, lumpish thing showed over to the right.

"There's the house," said Mother.

There was no light in the windows.

The man who drove the cart stooped, took out the key from under the doorstep, unlocked the door, went in and lit a candle. By its thin little glimmer, the children saw a large bare kitchen.

There was a rustling, scampering sound.

"Oh, what's that?" asked the children.

Why does Mother say having mice in the house is fun?

"It's only the mice," said the cart man.

"What fun!" said Mother."This is quite an adventure, isn't it?"

They lit a fire in the dining room. Everyone was very, very tired, but cheered up at the sight of the funny and delightful supper. There were biscuits, the Marie and the plain kind, sardines, raisins, and marmalade!

whirling: confusing and exciting crockery: plates, cups, dishes, etc dusk: the time of day (evening) when the light has almost gone but it is not yet dark roused: woken up, especially when one is sleeping deeply stooped: bent forward and downward glimmer: small, unsteady light rustling: the sound of light, dry things moving together scampering: moving quickly with short light steps sardines: small sea fish raisins: dried grapes marmalade: jam/jelly made from oranges, lemons, etc.,

Next morning Roberta woke Phyllis saying, "We're in the new house. Let's get up and begin to be useful. We'll just creep down mouse-quietly, and have everything beautiful before Mother gets up. I've woken Peter. He'll be dressed as soon as we are."

They lighted the fire and put the kettle on, and they arranged the crockery for breakfast. When there seemed to be nothing more that they could do, they went out again into the fresh bright morning.

They went out to the yard and watched the hilly country below. They could see the line of the railway down below. "Let's sit down a bit," suggested Roberta. So they sat down on a great flat grey stone that had pushed itself up out of the grass; and when Mother came out to look for them at eight o'clock, she found them deeply asleep in a contented, sun-warmed bunch.

Edith Nesbit (1858–1924) was an English author whose writing covered a wide range: poems, plays, novels, ghost stories, fantasies of magic and time-travel, and tales of country life. She is best remembered for her adventure stories for children. Her better known books include: *The Treasure Seekers, The Wouldbegoods, The Story of the Amulet and The Enchanted Castle*.

*The Railway Children* (1905) tells the story of a family who has to leave their home and move to a house near a railway track when the father is imprisoned due to false charges.

In this section, we will:
- remember details about the story.
- learn how to analyse the structure of a story.

(C-2.1, C-2.2)

# Make connections

## Map the story

The setting of a story tells us when and where the events happen. The weather and the atmosphere of a place also add to the setting.

**Write whether the following statements about the story setting are true (T) or false (F).**

1. The first part of the story takes place in a red-brick-fronted villa. ◯
2. At first, life at the red-brick-fronted villa was comfortable and cheerful. ◯
3. The two gentlemen met Father in the dining room one morning. ◯

creep: to move carefully in order to not be seen or heard  mouse-quietly: very quietly  contented: happy or satisfied

4. After the visit of the two gentlemen, the atmosphere at the red-brick-villa was even more cheerful.
5. The railway platform was cold, dark and gloomy.
6. The setting of the story shifts from a red villa to a small cottage.

## Deep dive

**Answer the following questions with reference to context.**

1. *A few days later Mother came down to breakfast. She looked pale but she smiled and said, "Now, my pets, we're going to leave this house, and go and live in the country. I know you'll love it."*

| RECALL | INFER | ANALYSE |
|---|---|---|
| a. Who were the 'pets' being addressed by Mother?<br>b. What had happened that led Mother to make this announcement? | c. How do we know that Mother herself was worried about the situation? | d. Mother expressed words of encouragement to her 'pets' along with the announcement. What can you say to someone who has to leave their house? |

2. *Next morning Roberta woke Phyllis saying, "We're in the new house. Let's get up and begin to be useful. We'll just creep down mouse-quietly and have everything beautiful before Mother gets up. I've woken Peter. He'll be dressed as soon as we are."*

| RECALL | INFER | ANALYSE |
|---|---|---|
| a. What did the children do to make the house beautiful before their mother woke up? | b. How do we know from the sentences given that the children were thoughtful and caring towards their mother? | c. What do you think you can do to help your family if you move into a new house? |

## Read, reflect and write

1. What kind of life did the children lead in their old house?
2. Towards the end of this part of the story from 'The Railway Children', Mother said that it was fun to have mice in the house and the move was quite an adventure. Why do you think she said this? What values did she want to give her children?

## Integrate

In the story there is mention of a train, a cab and a cart. Draw up a chart of all the vehicles you can name. After listing all the vehicles you can think of, research the different ways vehicles impact the environment. Now, circle the ones that you think are the most eco-friendly and cause the least pollution.

# Word wall

In this section, we will:
- find antonyms of some words from the story.
- practise vocabulary by connecting pairs of words in a word ladder. (C-4.1, 4.2)

## Antonyms

**From the story, find antonyms of the words given below.**

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| similar | emptied | smooth | decorated | uneven | unhappy |

## Word ladders

Word ladders are puzzles in which you must connect a pair of words with other words by changing one letter at a time. For example, dog connects to cat like this: dog, dot, cot, cat.

The famous author Lewis Carroll created many word-ladder puzzles.

**Now read the clues given below and make word ladders.**

1. Use the clues given to change READ to BOOK.
   - a tiny round object put on a string and worn as jewellery
     _____
   - to defeat others in a race or a game
     _____
   - a vehicle you row
     _____
   - knee-length footwear
     _____
   - something we read
     _____

2. Use the clues given to change WELL to ROOF.
   - used to ring the hour of the day
     _____
   - holds up trousers
     _____
   - a door fastener
     _____
   - an enclosed space at the back of a car for carrying luggage or other goods
     _____
   - the part of a plant that holds it in the ground
     _____
   - the upper covering of a building
     _____

In this section, we will:
- learn to identify and use conjunctions of time. (C-3.4, 4.2)

# Grammar time

## Conjunctions of time

ANCHOR CHART

**Conjunctions** or joining words that tell us about the *time* of events or happenings are called conjunctions of time.

These conjunctions tell us about the time or answer the question on when something happened.

- When did the mouse run past them?
  As soon as they opened the door, a mouse ran past them.
- When did the children wake their mother?
  The children woke their mother when breakfast was ready.

Here are some more conjunctions of time:

*whenever* *when* *until* *since* *before* *while* *as long as*

**1. Join the pairs of sentences by using the conjunctions given in brackets. The first one has been done for you.**

a. She returned from the market. She was tired. (when)
*She was tired when she returned from the market.*

b. Alistair hid. He saw his friends. (as soon as)

c. We waited at the station. Our grandfather arrived. (until)

d. Shweta ate dinner. She watched a film. (after)

e. You are waiting. Have a cup of tea. (while)

f. We begin our work. The bell rings. (when)

g. I go out in the rain. I take an umbrella with me. (whenever)

**2. Complete these sentences with ideas of your own.**

a. As soon as I go home, _____.

b. While you finish your work _____.

c. When you reach school _____.

d. _____ until you tidy the room.

e. After my examination _____.

f. _____ before the train arrived.

In this section, we will:
- learn how to end a sentence in different ways. (C-1.1)

# Punctuation

## Ending a sentence

Read these sentences.

- They went out to the yard and watched the hilly country below.
- Oh, what's that?
- What fun!

Sentences can end with a full stop, a question mark or an exclamation mark.

Sentences that give information or make requests end with a full stop ( . ).
Sentences that ask questions end with a question mark ( ? ).
Sentences that express strong feelings and excitement end with an exclamation mark ( ! ).

**Use a full stop, question mark or an exclamation mark correctly at the end of these sentences.**

1. Is it eight o'clock _____
   It is eight o'clock _____
   Look at the time, I'm late _____
2. I am going to the market this afternoon _____
   How expensive things are _____
   What will you buy _____
3. Has Pallavi gone to the library _____
   Pallavi has gone to the library to borrow a book _____
   What a good story this is _____
4. How hot it is _____
   It is a hot day _____
   How hot is it _____

# Write well

In this section, we will:
- look at a picture and write a story based on it. (C-3.2, 3.4)

## Picture story

**Look at the picture given. What do you think is in the box? What do you think happens next? Use your imagination and write a story based on the picture in your notebook. Add illustrations to the story.**

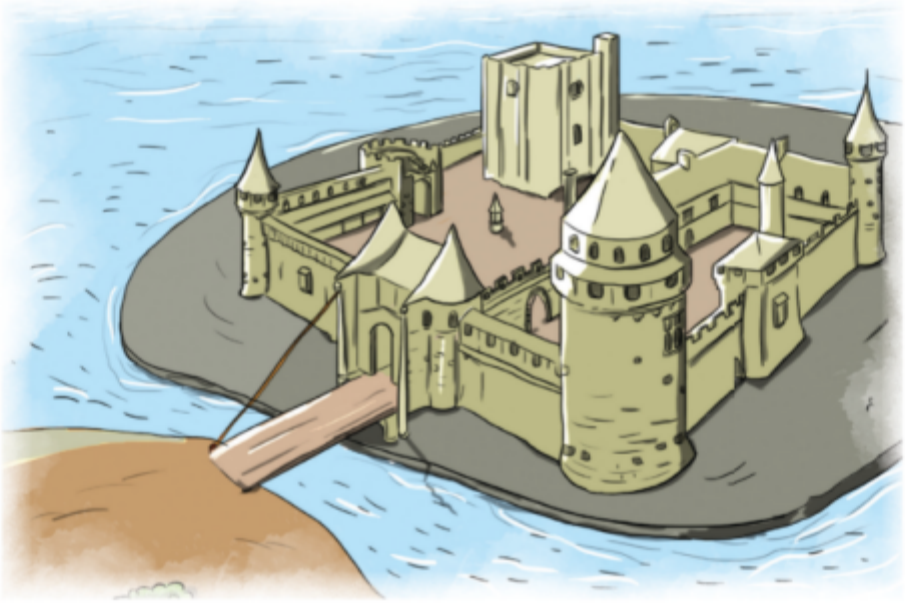
# Listen and speak well

In this section, we will:
- listen to a description on the different parts of a castle and label the diagram.
- describe pictures of buildings to each other.
- speak about our homes and why they are special.

(C-1.1, 1.3, 2.1, 4.1, 4.2)

1. **The children in the story moved from one house to another. There are many different types of houses. Castles are large buildings with strong walls. Listen to the description of the different parts of a castle and label the diagram given below.**

bailey moat keep gatehouse drawbridge arrowloops towers ramparts



2. **Work in pairs to describe the pictures of the buildings given below. Here are a few sentence prompts you may use.**

All have … Some have … None has … Each has …

3. **Draw a picture of your home. What is your favourite place at home? What makes your home a special place for you? Take turns in speaking about your home.**